Ferozepur and Zira *tehsils*, on grounds of accessibility to good irrigation. Between 8 and 12 August, when the final award was made, the Maharaja took the first tangible step towards accession to India, when on 11 August he sacked Premier Kak. After his sacking, Kak was arrested at Srinagar airport while boarding an aircraft with his English wife, Margaret. It is said that both the IG Police Richard Powell and Maj. Gen. Scott assisted him in this foiled attempt at escape.[19] An enraged Maharaja completely isolated him by placing him under house arrest. It appears that the Maharaja's resolve was also strengthened by his wife and her brother Nishchant Chand Katoch, who had lobbied for accession to India and the sacking of Kak. So, by 12 August 1947, the Maharaja had travelled one-third of the way to fulfilling Gandhi's wishes.

At the same time, Ismay was in radio contact with Col. Bacon who had now taken over as the Political Agent in Peshawar. Bacon, in turn, was in radio contact with Brown in Gilgit. Plans were being crystallised to stage a *coup d'état* in Gilgit, with as little bloodshed and disturbance as possible. The goal was to get the whole Gilgit Agency to accede to Pakistan.[20] The code name of the operation was to be 'Datta Khel'.

Col. Bacon's former Parsee radio operator called Limbuwala was to use one-time pads to communicate with another trusted member of Col. Bacon's team, wireless operator Donaldson. Limbuwala had spent many years in Kashgar, Sinkiang as a radio operator and cipher clerk at the British Consulate. He was married to a girl from Kashgar and was, in all probability, actually employed by MI 6, as was Donaldson.

The operationalisation of Datta Khel was contingent upon Maharaja Hari Singh acceding to India. Maj. Brown was strategising his best options.

Prime Minister Kak's government was now replaced by one led by Maj. Gen. Janak Singh. Maharaja Hari Singh was now busy with getting India and Pakistan to sign standstill agreements with his state.

Sheikh Abdullah was freed from prison and was contemplating his next moves. Sardar Muhammad Ibrahim Khan was in the hill station of Murree in West Punjab, preparing for the Poonch uprising.